between the clouds and I was seeing the Pacific Ocean.

7 It may have been a lucky day indeed. Decades later it turned out that leukemia was substantially more common among people who had at one time observed atomic-bomb tests than among those who hadn't.

Discharge

At 5:00 p.m. local time on May 28, 1946, the plane touched down near San Francisco and I was back on continental United States soil after eighty days. That evening I called my father and heard his voice for the first time in nearly three months. I had failed in my attempt to get Gertrude, so I asked him to pass on the news of my return.

To my astonishment, he seemed displeased at my return. He wanted to know why I had been sent back.

I said, "The Army stopped Gertrude's allotment because they said I was discharged. They sent me back to look into the matter."

My father said, "It will look funny for the customers. They might think there was something wrong."

And I said, with more than a touch of impatience, "The hell with the customers. I'm not going to stay five thousand miles away from home just because they might think it's funny. If you think more of them than you do me, that's your problem."

I was furious with my father, but eventually I found out what was bothering him. A postwar letter from his brother Boris had informed him that his brother Samuel was an officer in the Red Army—possibly a major or a major general (it was difficult to figure out the meaning of the Russian word).

My father had passed on the news to me and I had mentioned it to my friends in Hawaii as an item of humor. My father thought that this might have activated Army suspicions of me. 1

On May 30, 1946, I took the train East. I had an upper berth to myself this time. The next day I was back in Ogden, Utah, where I didn't bother to buy a postcard, or even get off the train. I was alone on this journey and I didn't trust my sense of direction. On June 1, in fact, when we stopped in Omaha, I recorded in my diary,